Serhii Khomenko

Stories and Essays

Contents

Family and Roots.....5

1. Mum.....7

2. Dad.....10

3. Grandma.....13

4. Grandad.....16

5. All of You Are in Me.....19

Childhood and Loved Ones.....20

6. The Museum.....22

7. Ladies' Choice.....24

8. The Warmth of Winter.....26

9. Walking in the Rain.....29

10. A Seed of Understanding and Love.....34

11. A Gift for Someone Worthy.....38

12. The Prickly Hedgehog.....41

13. The Pain Inside.....43

On Myself and the World Within.....44

14. An Oversalted Sea of Feelings.....46

15. The Instrument of Sleep.....48

16. Catching Thoughts on the Fly.....50

17. The Magpie.....53

18. Loneliness.....55

19. Becoming a Tree.....58

Love and Closeness.....59

20. Rendezvous.....61

21. A Little Secret.....67

22. The Ice Desert.....70

23. The Heart.....76

24. Stopping Time.....79

25. The Goddess of a New World.....85

Time and the Path.....88

26. The Bell.....90

27. The Mechanism of Being.....92

28. Life in Bloom.....94

29. So I'm on the Right Path.....97

Images and Other Worlds.....101

30. A Strange Friend.....103

31. The Catch.....106

32. The Visor Drops.....109

33. The Last Watch.....112

34. I Walked Away.....115

35. As the Gods Made Me.....124

36. The Seventh Friday.....129

37. How Beautiful Mars Is.....132

About the Author.....133

Rights and Use.....134

A Note on the Translation.....135

Family and Roots


Mum
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
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1. Mum

Mum, you haven't picked me up for so long,
what's wrong?
Have you been like this for long?

Where are you, why aren't you here?

I'm looking for your warmth, crawling about the floor,
I'm lonely.

Mum, my world is still too small,
too hard to understand.

Why am I here?
It was good with you, I know it was.

You love me,
nobody else loves me, not yet.
Why am I here?

I'm crying.

You come over and pick me up,
I see your smile,
it's the only thing I understand,
I'm still too little.

You hold me close, I calm down.

You charge me up with love,
now I know why I'm here –
I have to find my own.

I have to find you in someone else, in the woman I love.

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 09:25:45 · UTC+0200


DAD
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
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2. Dad

Dad, you were always strong,
I was afraid of you.
I suppose you have to be like that,
I suppose life is cruel.

I feel sorry for myself,
I hate you,
I hate you for being the way you are.

I suppose everyone's like that,
I suppose that's how you have to be to survive.

You pick me up and toss me into the air,
I feel myself flying,
I feel so light.

You smile...

I didn't know you could be like this,
maybe you're not always the same.

You're talking to me.
I'm listening, but all I can think about
is the thud of a football against the garage doors.

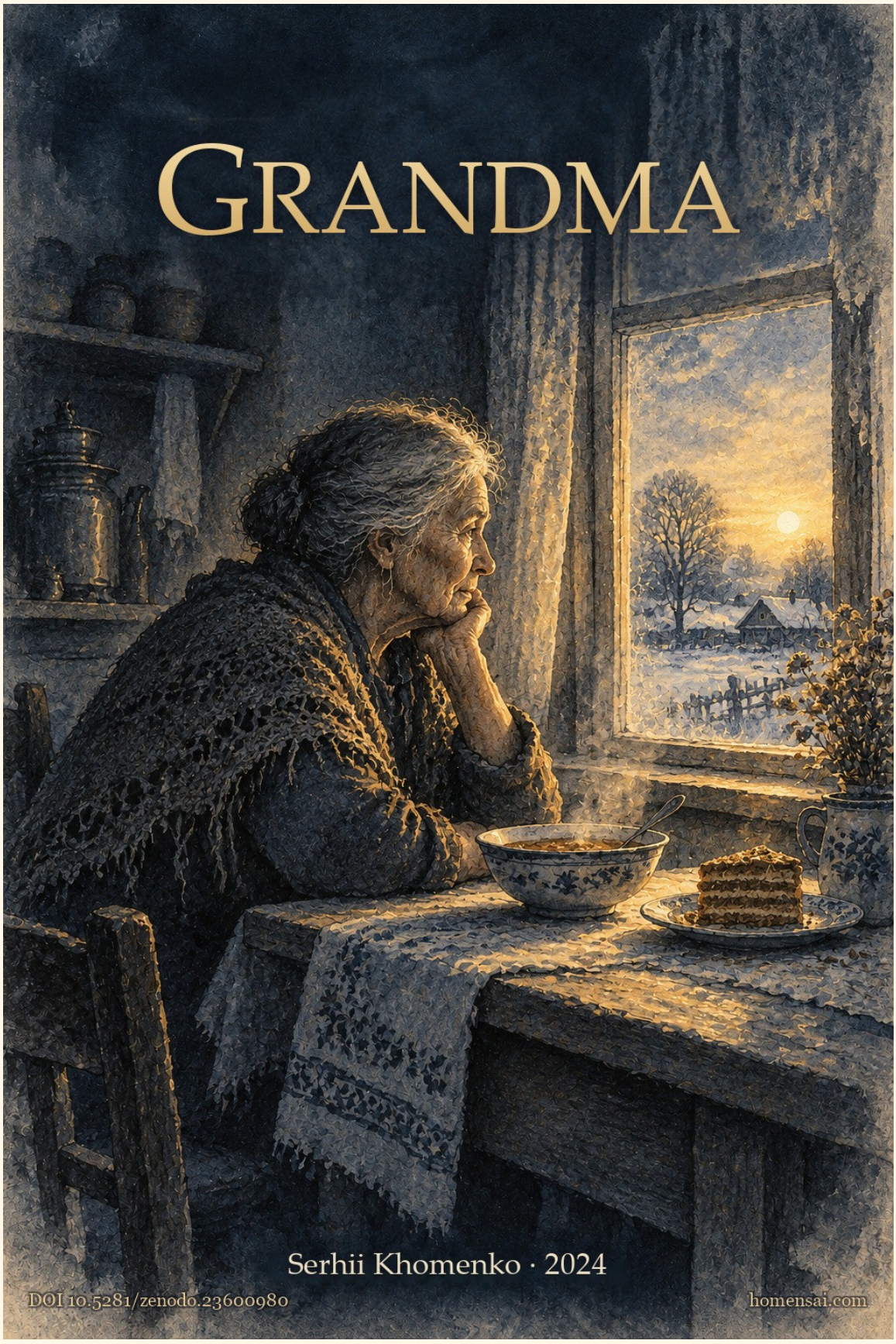
I'm a child,
what are you telling me,
I can't hear you.
I want to be running about out there,
it's pulling me out there,
let me go...

Today I did something bad,
you shout at me, you hit me,
I hate you, I hate myself.

You're strong, it's easy for you.
I'm weak, I'm looking for myself in this world,
I'm testing how much it can take.

Sometimes I feel a kind of tenderness,
it's a different tenderness,
something not like Mum's,
I don't know what it is,
but it's there...

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 09:33:47 · UTC+0200


GRANDMA
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
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3. Grandma

Grandma, I remember that strange, endless sadness of yours,
Grandad used to call you the Countess.

I remember your borscht made with old salo,
it was unbelievably good,
sort of creamy, delicate, divine.

Your cabbage rolls were delicious,
your 'Napoleon' cake – nobody made it better,
now I understand
that it was you, not Mum, who gave me my taste for food.

And I always wondered where this refinement of mine came from.
It was simply that Grandad's Countess passed a little piece of herself on to me.

Countesses – they're like that...

Much later I found out
that my mum could have had a brother or a little sister…
Maybe that's what she was missing, my mum.

But you had an abortion, you didn't dare,
the world turned out to be stronger than you.

And that sorrow was stamped on your face for ever.

My poor grandma…

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 10:15:15 · UTC+0200


GRANDAD
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4. Grandad

Grandad, I remember you from when I was little.

A jolly soul, carefree.
You're playing the tambourine,
your brother the accordion,
Volodya the spoons.

I see happiness in you,
it's a rare gift.
I ask myself: where do you get it from?
Who taught you to be happy?

You're having fun, and I'm happy.

Heart-to-heart talk flows over the vodka,
warmth seeps down through my legs,
I watch and drink in this happiness,
I'm tipsy on it myself by now.

I'll be starting school soon,
the thought worries me.
I get distracted.

Oh-oh-oh, here comes the dancing :)
And you dance your strange, wild sort of dance,
never letting go of your instruments.

I watch and see energy,
strange and wild somehow.
Where does it come from in you?

You look funny, but you don't care,
you laugh, and so do I, who knows why,
I suppose the wave caught me up,
I relax,
I want to dive in with you too,
to be as young as you are,
my beloved grandads.

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 10:13:35 · UTC+0200


ALL OF YOU
ARE IN ME
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

5. All of You Are in Me

Mum – thank you,
you taught me to love,
even though it isn't easy.

Dad, you taught me to be strong,
showed me what I have to be for my other half,
you didn't always do it well,
but you did it as best you could, with your father's love.

Grandma, thank you for teaching me to feel flavours.

Grandad, thank you for teaching me to be cheerful
and for making me rich,
for teaching me to count money...
I still give your jokes away to others,
I catch them in myself...

Thank you all for making,
for trying to make me happy,
without even realising it.

Now you are all in me,
and I am the way I am...

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 10:00:01 · UTC+0200

Childhood and Loved Ones


THE MUSEUM
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

6. The Museum

I haven't been to a museum for a long time.

My father was always busy at the factory,
they were making some baffling thing there.
He tried to explain it to me, but for now,
since I'm still small,
that section of my brain wasn't accessible,
I didn't understand...

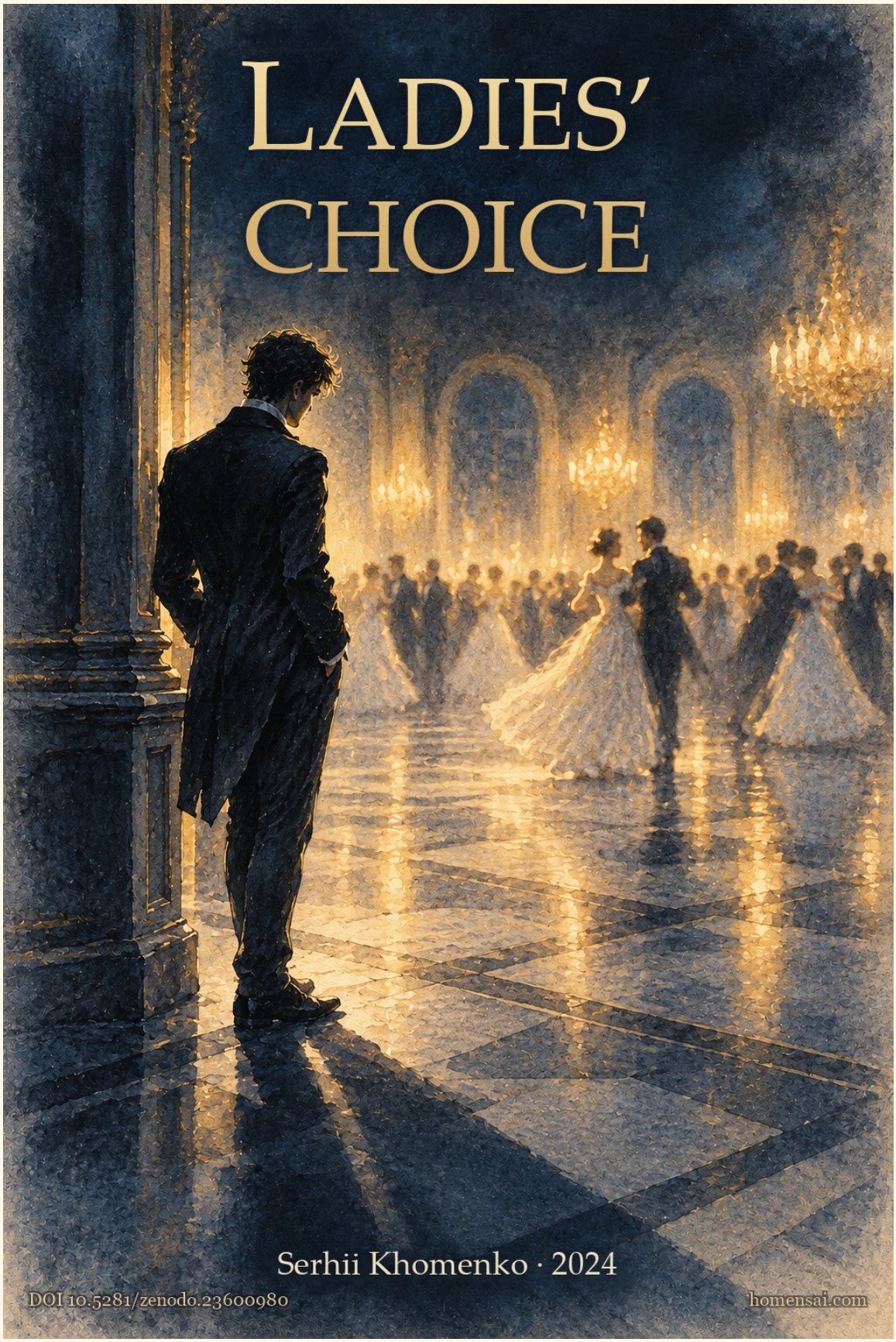
I had been waiting for this day for ages, dreaming of it.
I could just feel it, really,
how proudly I would walk, holding his hand,
down the long corridors.
Looking at the exhibits.

I will grow up.
And as I move along, they will grant me access
to new sections, new segments of my brain.

And now the day has come.

I walk proudly beside my dad,
growing more grown-up.
And I think I'm already beginning to understand
what he does at the factory...

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 07:13:29 · UTC+0200


LADIES'
CHOICE
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

7. Ladies' Choice

It seems strange now,
but as a child I hated them.
I hated ladies' choice, the slow dances.

I hated myself.

Nobody wanted to dance with me,
nobody ever asked me for ladies' choice...

I hoped someone would pick me,
pay me some attention.
And I just stood there,
pretending I didn't care...

And my heart fluttered with hope.

I stand there, crying inside...
And I don't understand why nobody wants me,
what's wrong with me...

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 23:52:22 · UTC+0200


THE WARMTH OF WINTER
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

8. The Warmth of Winter

I'm standing.
Evening.
The yellow sun of a lamp is shining.

Big flakes of snow are falling,
they land on me,
whirl and dance in the light of the street lamp.

This sight always spellbinds me.
I have always seen magic in it...

I feel so good inside, somehow,
as if I'm in a fairy tale.
Some endless New Year fairy tale of childhood.

I love watching these white-and-yellow flakes...
They fall slowly all around,
adorning the world with their beauty.

I first noticed this feeling as a child,
walking home after swimming.
I moved through this beautiful, spellbinding world.
And even then, at 11,
I wanted to keep these impressions, these sensations for ever.

Winter, I love it when you're like this,
when you give me your fairy tale, your story...
When you let me see your warmth
through the cold and cruelty of the world...

You give me hope...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 06:35:43 · UTC+0200


WALKING IN THE RAIN
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

9. Walking in the Rain

Walking in the rain.
Today the little ones and I went on a hike.

Masha was worried because rain was forecast.
I said, 'Ah, sod the rain, we're not scared of it.'

We came out through the woods at the viewpoint,
brilliant view.

We spotted a swing – such a fun one,
a log you can sit on from both ends, two at a time.
I sat with Dasha, Masha with Seryozha.
We had a great time swinging,
I can't even remember the last time that happened :)

When you come, I'll take you there,
it's brilliant :)

Anyway, we see a storm cloud racing in,
Masha's getting nervous – she wants to go home.
All right, off we go.

We're walking, it starts to drizzle.
I'm in just a T-shirt and a cap,
my tracksuit top's in my rucksack,
but I'm deliberately not putting it on.

The rain's only light :)

I raise both arms to the sky
and shout at the top of my voice, 'Come on, chuck
some more down!' :)
And the sky, hearing my call,
turns the rain up :)

Seryozha and I walk along, talking about the rain...

The rain gets heavier,
it was 19 degrees out,
I'm starting to get wet,
my mesh trainers are soaked through,
my feet squelch.

I know this feeling,
it was the same in China,
when Yura and I walked around Beijing
in shoes full of water.

My T-shirt is getting wetter,
the wind is blowing.
I'm trying to work out when I'll get cold,
when I'll reach that limit,
the point where I can't take any more.

Strange, but I'm not cold.

I've come to love the rain, made my peace with it,
and I'm testing it on myself, sort of relaxed.
Not cold at all, strange.
Only the squelching inside my trainers bothers me a bit.

I walk on and wait.
I realise I'm already soaked, I've reached the limit
and I'm not getting any wetter,
and somehow I don't care any more.

I always wanted to understand
what it's like not to be afraid of the rain.
And now I do :)

We get home,
the hot shower burns, like in winter.
Strange, my body was so cold,
but I didn't feel it. Strange.

I went and had a look at the thermometer,
it was +14 outside,
and I didn't even get cold...

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 16:15:24 · UTC+0200


A SEED OF
UNDERSTANDING AND LOVE
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

10. A Seed of Understanding and Love

This evening Dasha, as always,
asks me to tell her a story.
And I, as always, say yes.

You remember that I can't just tell a story as it is.
With me it isn't simply static,
it's alive,
it changes as I tell it.

Nobody ever did that for me,
but I feel that's how it has to be done for them.
I can't do it any other way.

Tonight it's the turn of 'The Enormous Turnip'.

As I tell it, I begin to understand what this tale means
myself,
for the first time in my whole life.
I understand what it's about,
I never understood before.

It's about family, about a team,
about how every contribution matters,
even the tiiiniest.
About family being a team.
That everything matters.

I've told you this already –
you and I are a team.
Maybe they'll start to understand it too.

That even the mouse's little effort
makes a huge difference at the end...

I added to the tale at the beginning,
I don't know why myself, with the words:
'A very rich father left Grandad one single seed as his inheritance.'

It just burst out of me.
Like, bang, and I'd said it without thinking,
where did that line come from?
I don't know.

And Grandad didn't know what to do with it.

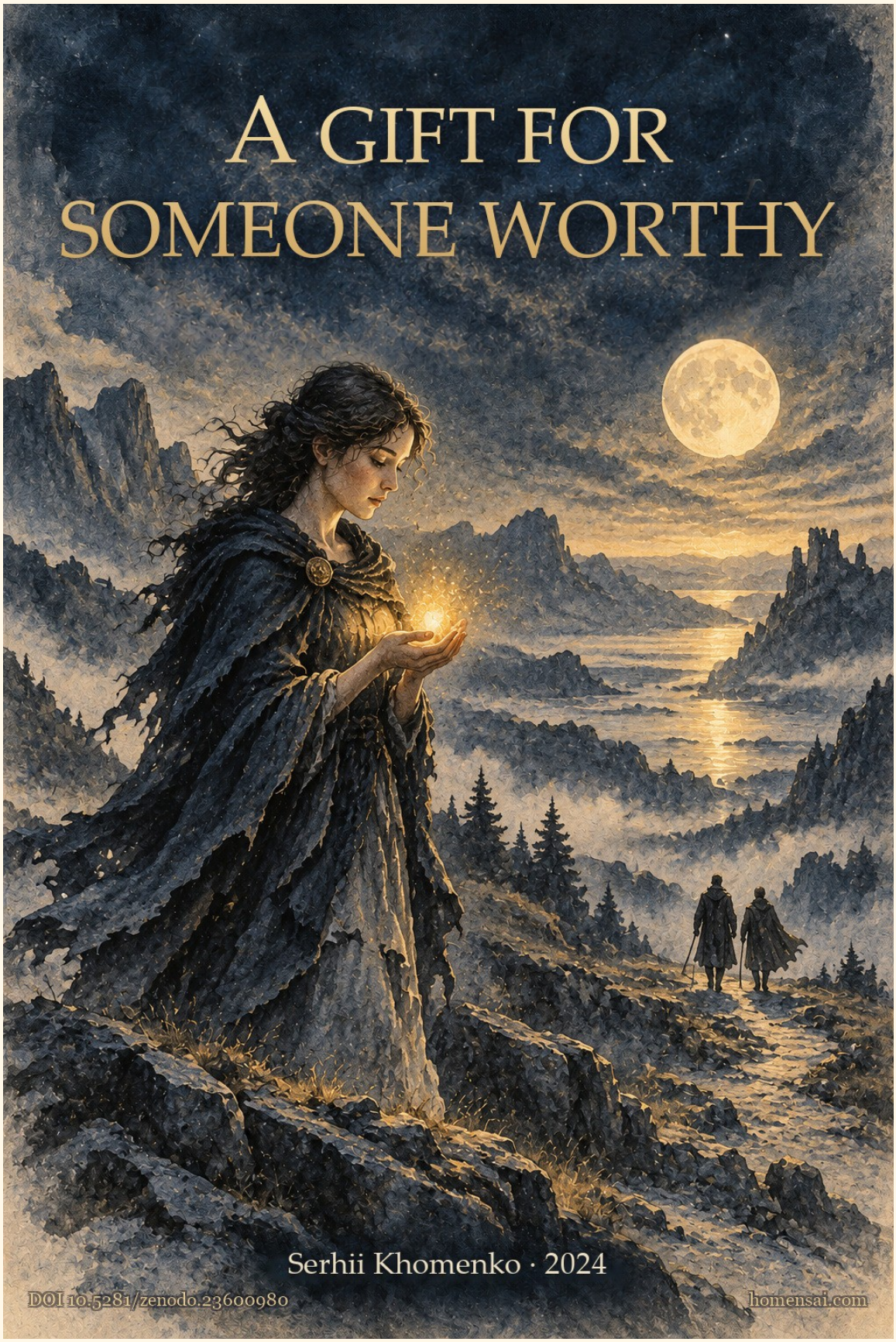
So what was this seed?
And why was it the only thing the rich father left him?

Maybe we should give our children a seed like that too?
Maybe it's important?
And it's the most precious thing in life?

Maybe that's our mission.
Maybe that's the seed of understanding and love...

I know it sounds a bit odd here –
a grandad leaving it to a grandad,
but maybe that's how it's meant to be,
maybe it shows the bond between generations,
maybe that matters too...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 03:43:18 · UTC+0200; 23/06/2024 · 03:52:22 · UTC+0200; 23/06/2024 · 03:53:58 · UTC+0200


A GIFT FOR SOMEONE WORTHY
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

11. A Gift for Someone Worthy

Last night Masha suddenly started telling me, laughing,
about Ilya.
That he'd invited her over for a barbecue,
out of the blue somehow, it was odd.

I told her that in that case we'd all go :)
She laughed, he didn't get it.

It seems to me that when she talks about him
her face lights up,
maybe she likes him?
And I feel sort of glad inside.

'Maybe it's the full moon,' she says,
and I tell her how things go at the full moon.

I've just woken up and written to her about pick-up,
about how it helped me find you.

And that she should value herself like gold.
That he should be the one to come here.
And that she should offer him walks, not meat.
Maybe even by moonlight.

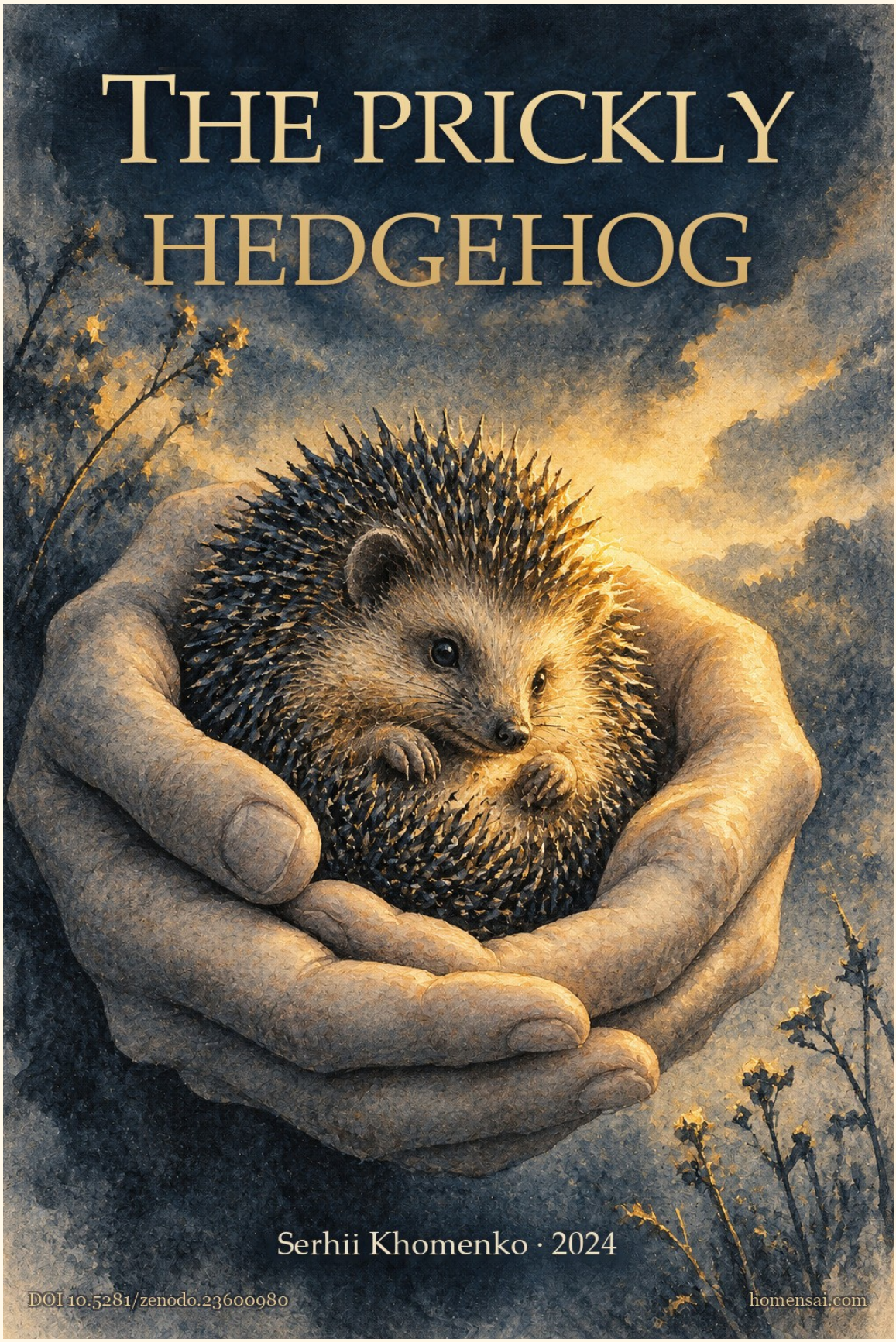
And that she should talk to you, you'll give her advice.

I think she's had a bit of a rest from Vanya by now.
Maybe she really is ready for something?
Maybe she's grown up?

Tell them about us, as an example,
about the kiss, and how and when it happened.
How much it matters to a man.
How you valued yourself and didn't give it to just anyone.

And that that's where the value lies,
that it matters.
That it's an important gift,
and you should only give it to someone worthy.
Someone you have to search for all your life...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 05:54:14 · UTC+0200


THE PRICKLY HEDGEHOG
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

12. The Prickly Hedgehog

Purik was such a prickly, huffing little hedgehog.
He wasn't scary, just a very important hedgehog.

I picked him up,
and he curled into a ball.
How can I unroll you and see what's inside...

I waited, and he unrolled,
such a little hedgehog, and no longer prickly.

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 06:24:10 · UTC+0200


THE PAIN INSIDE
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

13. The Pain Inside

Lying here, I thought of Palych, of Yura...
And somehow I felt a wild,
unbearable pity for Yura.
It twisted me up, right to the point of tears...

He's on his own now, abandoned in a wasteland,
a deadly wasteland.

An impulse bursts out of me upwards,
somewhere into space,
and flies off in an inexplicable stream...

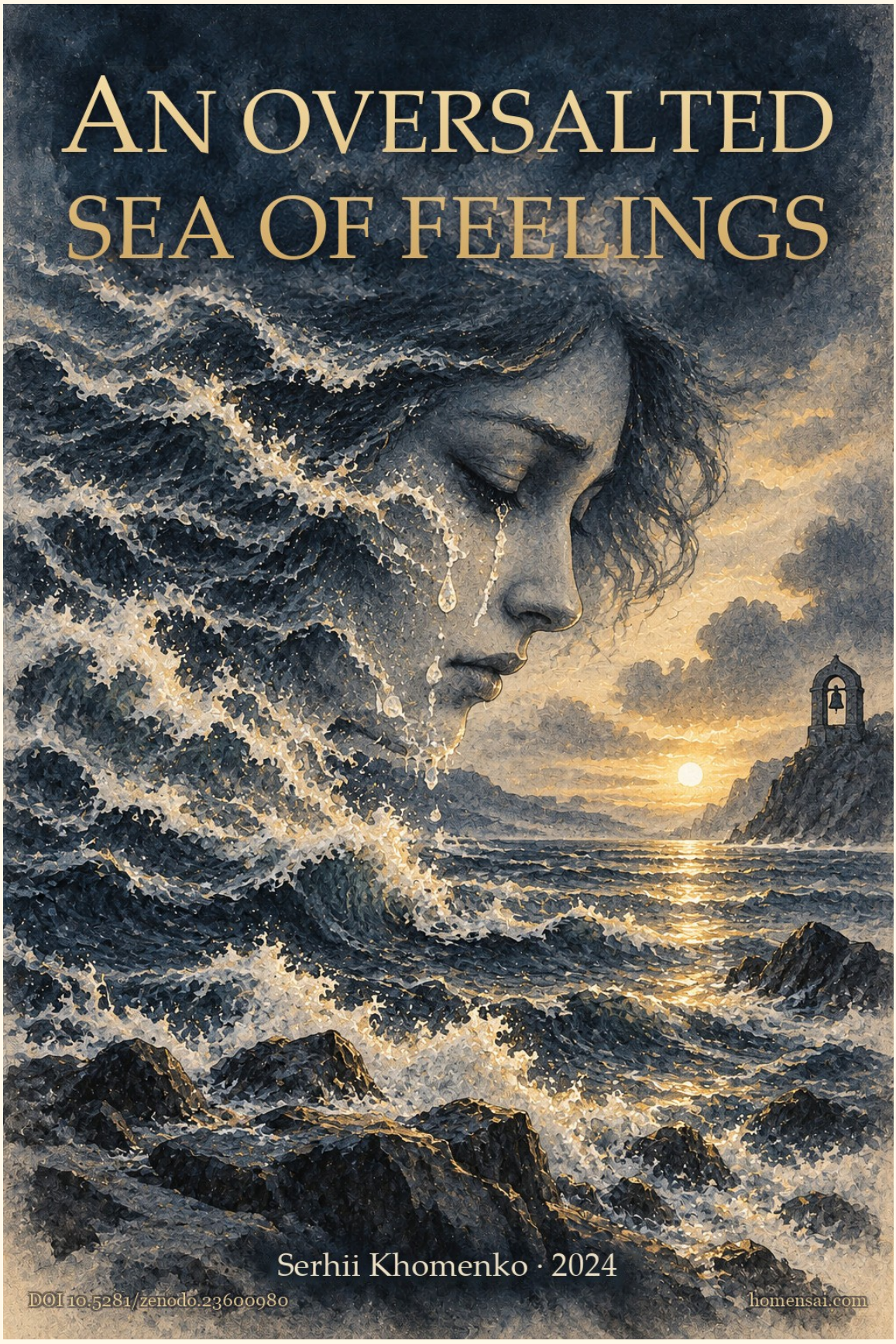
I'm writing, and it's getting easier.
The pain has quietened down.

But I know it's still inside me...
It wants to live with me, it likes it here.

Today I'll call Palych.
I'll ask him to help Yura,
he's alone now, he's lonely...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 06:11:19 · UTC+0200

On Myself and the World Within


AN OVERSALTED
SEA OF FEELINGS
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

14. An Oversalted Sea of Feelings

I'm tired of crying.
I hadn't cried for a long time.
Even when Mum died I didn't cry like this.
I suppose everything takes time.

The bell is tolling again.
My eyes are already stinging from the salt.
For a week now I've been swimming in an oversalted sea of feelings.

My eyes hurt,
the salt is dissolving them,
sharpening the sensations,
not letting me forget.

Again I beg myself not to cry
and yet once again I can't hold back,
I realise: it's impossible...

Something inside is vibrating hard, really hard,
it feels as if I'm merging with the universe,
the frequencies match,
and I have to do something, something important.

But I don't know what.
And it's getting to me...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 08:10:24 · UTC+0200


THE INSTRUMENT OF SLEEP
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

15. The Instrument of Sleep

I want to sleep.
Simply, without a care, like when I was a child.
I want to fall into the arms of my bed
and switch off, forget myself.

The pillow beckons me,
but now it won't let me sleep.
Insomnia throws me into other worlds,
into other universes.

I lie here thinking.
It's night, isn't it, and night is meant for sleep,
isn't that right?

My eyes are closed, but sleep won't come,
it turns me down, won't let me have it.

I lie here wondering
when my instrument of sleep went out of tune,
and why...

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 06:46:30 · UTC+0200


CATCHING THOUGHTS
ON THE FLY
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

16. Catching Thoughts on the Fly

What I write is a tiny fraction of everything
that's in my head right now.

I try to distract myself,
to drive the thoughts away.
I don't want to write them all out,
it's very slow,
I won't say it's hard,
somehow that sounds trite,
but there's a certain strain.

I'd like to forget myself.
It won't let me.

There are so many images,
they circle like flies.

I snatch a fly and examine it,
it lies in my hand, legs in the air,
and smiles,
having let itself be caught.

Strange, but I never used to be able to catch flies in mid-air.
Now it's my gift...

What rubbish.

Thoughts aren't flies, are they,
so why do they buzz in my head
and keep me from sleeping?

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 08:16:48 · UTC+0200


THE MAGPIE
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

17. The Magpie

The magpie.

Every morning she flies up under my window.
Every morning I hear her nasty chatter.

I hate the magpie.

She has been flying to me for a long time, on purpose.
Isn't that strange?

She always wants to tell me something
and she does,
she sings to me in her own language.
She tells me about myself.

And I listen and hate her,
I don't understand...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 08:13:44 · UTC+0200


LONELINESS
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

18. Loneliness

Loneliness.

You said recently, 'We are all alone.'

God, what a brilliant thought!
And you're right!
Somehow I'd never thought about it before...

What a simple and heavy phrase,
what a cruel thought!

We all come alone and leave alone,
we live by ourselves with our own inner, lonely world,
which we cannot understand ourselves,
let alone anyone else...

In our three-dimensional world we are born
as lonely, faceless halves.

And great is the happiness when we find,
even if only for a very short while,
our own half, one just like ourselves.

And only then, if only for an instant,
for one tiny, teeny-weeny second,
can we become whole in this world of lonely halves.

The only problem is
that you can understand and value this only
when you become a lonely half again,
a half of your own universe,
drifting through life...

Message dates: 30/06/2024 · 01:53:57 · UTC+0200

Author's date in the text: 20/06/24 1:30


BECOMING A TREE
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

19. Becoming a Tree

I'm sitting on the balcony now,
looking at the trees...

The wind stirs their leaves, their branches.
It seems as if these aren't trees
but seaweed,
moving together, in time,
yielding to the currents of the sea.

And I watch their untroubled movements...
They move so easily, so relaxed,
no tension at all...

And it seems to me that they're happy in their own way,
just bathing in the gusts of wind,
silently giving in to its motion.

They are serenely calm.
They don't care what's happening around them.
They're wrapped up in their own memories,
their own world,
which is not ours to understand.

I look at them and realise
that I want to become a tree like that...

Message dates: 30/06/2024 · 10:11:47 · UTC+0200

Love and Closeness


RENDEZVOUS
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

20. Rendezvous

Rendezvous.

You're standing under an umbrella,
it's raining.

You're huddled up, you're cold,
your hands are numb.
And the rain keeps falling, it's evening, getting dark.
The wind keeps gusting, trying to take your umbrella,
to tear it away.

You hold on to it like an anchor.

The world has frozen still. It's cold.
The dusk sharpens the feeling.

You long for hot tea and a blanket.
This small miracle beckons.

I'm late, again,
work has tied me up,
again, like a little bird, I'm tethered to it,
worn out, ringed...

At last I break free of the shackles.

'Let me go!' I shout inside. 'Please, let me go...'

How slowly I walk,
how slowly time goes by,
the hands of the clock stand still,
it's like a dream.
Where is the stop,
why is it somewhere an eternity away from me,
why?

I'm angry at everything,
angry at myself, at time.

I'm flying, I'll be there soon,
just you wait for me.

It's raining.
The rain drizzles on, it doesn't care...

My broken umbrella, which should have been replaced
long ago,
is in my hand,
I always take it with me
out of habit somehow, automatically.

I get off at the stop,
my eyes search for you,
where are you?

I see you – joy fills me.
I walk towards you, the umbrella hanging from my hand,
damn, I've forgotten all about it,
I don't need it.
It dangles there like an empty space,
I don't notice it.

I don't notice anything around me,
I see only you,
tired, chilled to the bone,
you, who won't give in.

I walk, almost run.

I'm beside you.
I hold you, kiss you.

Give me your palms,
your small, childlike hands,
I take them in mine, big and warm.
I raise them to my lips
and breathe warmth on to them...

You smile, we say nothing.

I feel warm.
I've saved, I've saved my little bird.

Yes, I think I've forgotten something,
there's something else I have to do.

I remember.
I put my hand in my pocket,
feel something soft.

It's a rosebud,
how could I forget...
I bought it yesterday,
I don't know, I didn't want a bouquet.
Just one flower.

I hold it out to you and smile.

We walk together, holding hands,
it's cold, but we don't notice it any more.
The umbrella is over us.

The little flower is with you now,
it's yours now, look after it.

I'm happy.

We hold hands...
And ahead of us there is only a whole, enormous, happy Life...

Message dates: 20/06/2024 · 08:03:06 · UTC+0200


A LITTLE SECRET
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

21. A Little Secret

Today you bought cigarettes.
The thought of them had been sitting in your head for a long time, for ages.
It nagged at you, you wanted them.
You wanted to try once more, to remember.

And so you buy them, here they are,
a pretty packet.

Tempting.

'I want them, I want them,' a voice says inside.

So what now?

This is my little secret,
I don't want to share it.
Who knows, it's sort of embarrassing.
Sort of want to, and I don't know.

All right, I'll hide them for now.

We meet, I've brought the little box with me.
We chat.

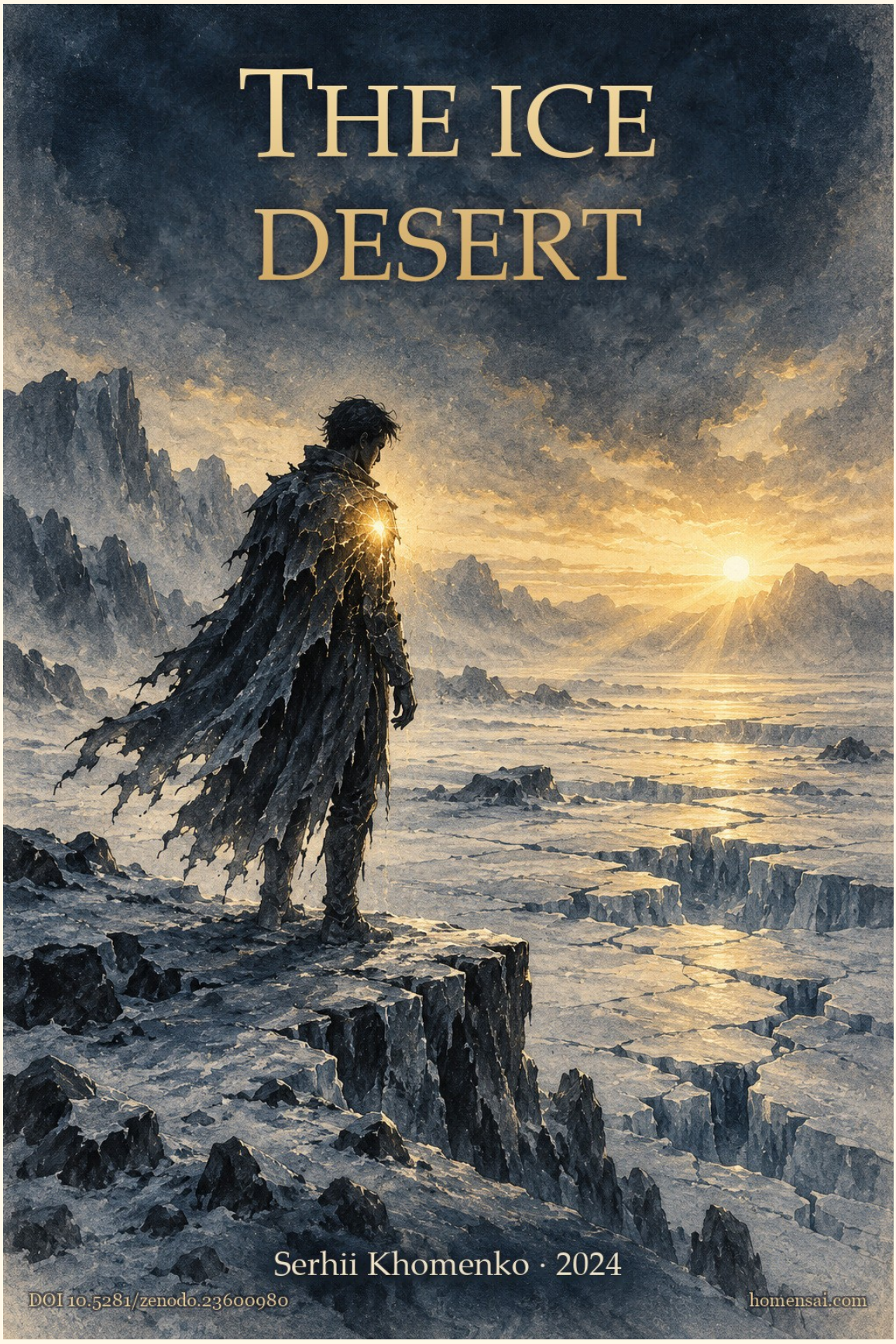
I feel the moment has come.
We sit down.

Well then, shall we try,
I've brought a little something.
Interest on your face, a smile, a question on your face.

I smile back – here.
I hold out my hand.

We sit, smoking...

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 16:37:31 · UTC+0200


THE ICE DESERT
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

22. The Ice Desert

When we arrived,
I felt that you mustn't come here...
Now I understand – I was protecting you.
Yes, it looked strange,
I didn't understand it myself,
now I've understood my motives.

It was protection,
I was protecting what was dear to me...

I put up a wall,
switched off my emotions,
I suppose that's how I survived,
I suppose that's how I kept you safe...

You saw what I was like when you met me,
I was cold...

That coldness helped me get through the trials,
it seemed to me it wasn't hard,
but I suppose, Irisha, it was very hard for me,
I suppose that's how it was.

And I covered myself in armour,
switched off my emotions,
just to survive.
And simply, as always, did what had to be done.

I suppose my father was in the same state,
we held on to one another like links in a chain,
and then the chain broke.

It hit him first, and me now.

And that's why the armour fell away from me,
that's how important it was.
I thought it was useless armour;
it was needed,
needed to survive.

You arrived, and I began to thaw.

Believe me, I myself was sickened
by my edginess, my coldness...
I didn't understand what was wrong with me,
I hated myself for it...

I was the one whose heart reality had pierced with an
icy dagger,
quickly and unnoticed.

The pain was dull, sharp,
I began to freeze,
I grew cold inside, very cold,
and at some point I got used to it,
bowed down before the Ice Queen.

You are my Germany,
you melted me again,
I came back.

That's what this fairy tale is about,
I've understood it now,
I didn't understand it before.

Now, having walked my path,
I've realised a lot, understood a lot,
and all of it has brought me
to where I am now.

With your endless faith and love
you melted me, do you understand?

Maybe you don't notice it,
the sun can't help being the sun,
you have warmth enough
to fill everything around you.

Without you I was sunk
in the gloomy, endless, icy desert of the night.
And I myself became that night,
that desert.

And only the moments we talked kept it from burying
me completely,
such a tiiiny little ray
shone right into my heart,
and yet I couldn't see it,
my eyes had already closed.

In the night it no longer matters whether they're open
or not,
I slowly began to turn into darkness.

It enveloped me,
began to squeeze me,
I became that darkness myself...

I became a shadow of myself...
I became someone else...

But your kiss, our first, kept me warm,
it left a mark on my heart,
it ate into it,
it became part of it.

It was that tiny drop
which kept me safe.

And it will stay in me for ever,
for ever, through time...

Message dates: 19/06/2024 · 06:56:25 · UTC+0200


THE HEART
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

23. The Heart

Something was born together with me.

Back then I didn't yet know what it was
or how important it would be to me in the future.
Something so small, fluttering.

I grew, and as I grew
I sometimes felt it.
Sometimes it hurt, sometimes it ached.

I heard it inside me,
tried to learn to live with it,
to come to some sort of agreement.

Whenever it made itself known,
I felt it,
and I was afraid,
I wanted it to just sort of exist on its own,
I didn't know what it was for.

I tried to come to terms with it, to talk to it...

And then I grew up and met you.
And we both fluttered.

It was like a lighthouse,
lighting the way.
It pointed me towards you,
whispering something inside.

And we became one, it and I,
my heart and I.

Message dates: 26/06/2024 · 06:43:36 · UTC+0200

Author's date in the text: 26/06/2024 6:42


STOPPING TIME
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

24. Stopping Time

You live in a small, cosy flat,
after work I buy flowers, oranges, a bar of chocolate
and head over to you,
practically racing…

I come in, you're wearing jeans and a shirt…
I give you the flowers.

You've baked a pie.
We sit drinking tea with the pie,
the orange is sweet,
the juice runs down our hands.

It's somehow so warm and cosy…
We chat about everything…

I don't want time to go on,
I want it to stop, to freeze…

I hate time.
It pushes me onwards,
and I don't want that.
I want to stay frozen in this moment for ever.

Then you put on some soft, melodic, calm music,
the lights are low.
We dissolve into the music,
sitting in silence, listening...

I hold out my hand to you
and with a nod invite you to dance.

You smile, get up,
I put my arm around your waist,
gently draw you close,
we dance slowly in time to the music,
our eyes closed...

I want to remember this moment
and I realise how hard that is...

I want to break free of the rush,
to shut away for a while,
to stuff my thoughts into a chest –
let them lie there for a bit at least...
I want a little freedom from them,
just the tiniest bit...
Just for one evening...

You're the first to kiss me on the lips,
I kiss you back...

Time has stopped,
it has become like a liquid,
filling the space around us,
a liquid you can touch...

I feel time with my body,
I understand what it is like now.
Now I understand how to stop time,
how it happens.

I don't know how much time has passed,
I've stopped feeling it...

The kiss dissolves me,
I become everything at once,
I merge with something around me,
I am the universe...

I quench my thirst for the kiss,
and now I'm calm,
I stroke your back,
you like it,
you arch it like a little cat,
so supple, so springy...

We sit down in the armchair,
you sit on my lap,
lay your little head on my chest,
put your arms around my shoulders.

I ask you to close your eyes.
And I begin to rock you in my arms, like a little girl.

You smile.
Your eyes are wet with tears.

You haven't felt this good for a long time...

You've forgotten what it's like.

Forgotten what it used to be like...

Message dates: 04/07/2024 · 08:37:20 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:38:15 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:38:30 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:38:49 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:39:01 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:41:28 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:42:23 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:43:22 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:44:06 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:45:39 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:47:07 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:47:22 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:48:57 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:50:13 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:51:16 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:53:08 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:54:09 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:54:26 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:54:42 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:54:50 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:55:13 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:55:30 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:55:41 · UTC+0200; 04/07/2024 · 08:55:48 · UTC+0200


THE GODDESS
OF A NEW WORLD
Serhii Khomenko · 2026
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

25. The Goddess of a New World

I haven't written anything for a long time,
but now and then I've started thinking about it.

I'm sitting at the table.
Evening.
The room is empty.

I'm holding a pencil in my hand
and staring blankly at a sheet of paper
lying on the table.

No thoughts,
in my head, as all around me, a dead emptiness.

Images are swirling,
but not the ones I want to see,
images of the past.
They often torment me,
though I understand that it's all over now
and I have to accept the new reality.

Out of the corner of my eye I see you,
you came in unnoticed, quietly.

You're standing in the doorway, leaning against the frame.
You're wearing a long, translucent white dress that reaches your feet.
Your hair falls to your shoulders in a golden waterfall.
You're smiling,
your big eyes look at me curiously.

Strange, but the hem of your dress stirs
in an invisible movement of wind
that isn't there.

I look at you.
I can sense some strange, ancient power in you.

You're barefoot.
You're pure, innocent,
you were born of the new world only recently.

Your divine nature is betrayed by a faint glow of your skin,
visible through the dress.
The light flows in strange waves,
reaching me.

You are the goddess of a new world.

I don't know why you've come,
but I'm grateful to you for it.

You touch me with your light,
filling my mind with new images.

I look at the paper and see
that it's no longer empty,
but full of new worlds, new words.

I see the fabric of reality,
I play on its strings a wonderfully harmonious melody,
lulling the world around me,
turning chaos into something new,
mysterious and tangible.

Message dates: 03/07/2026 · 11:01:43 · UTC+0200

Author's date in the text: 03/07/26 10:41

Time and the Path


THE BELL
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

26. The Bell

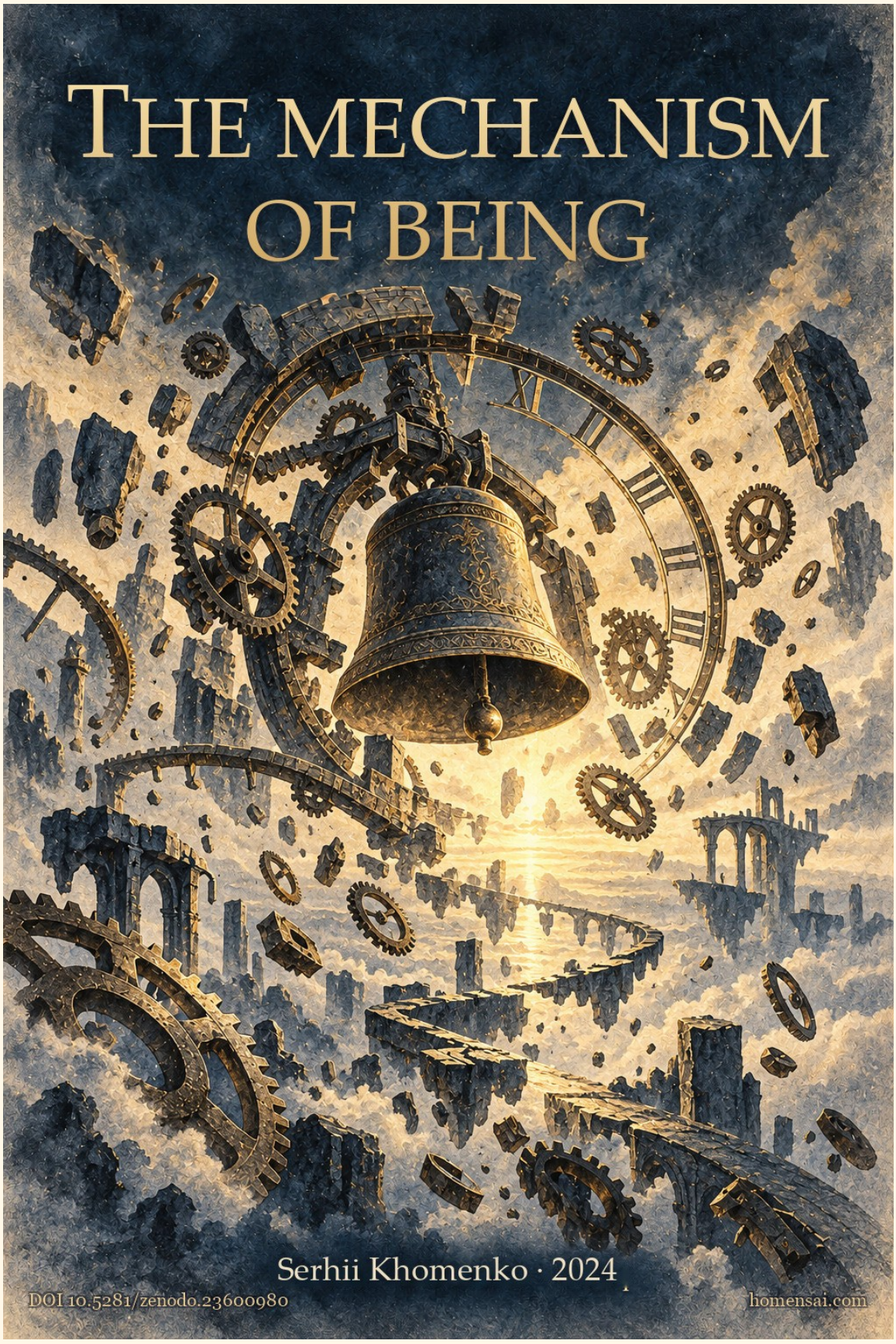
Somewhere outside the window a bell is tolling,
I hear it ringing all the time.
It strikes at me.

Now I understand what it means.
I didn't before.

Thank you, bell,
you remind me how fleeting life is...

It is a timer,
it is the knife of eternity,
paring layers of time off me,
the time still left for us...

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 06:17:10 · UTC+0200


THE MECHANISM OF BEING
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

27. The Mechanism of Being

A strange world around us,
which has thrown the incompatible into one heap
and laid it on its mechanism of being...

Clack, clack, clack – it sounds inside the mechanism.
Bong – the bell has struck, measuring out time.

Everything came together into a single whole
and at the bell's command
fell apart into pieces again.

And so it will be almost for ever.

Until the time of this world of ours runs out
and the time of a new one begins,
of a different world.

Message dates: 23/06/2024 · 08:22:08 · UTC+0200


LIFE IN BLOOM
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

28. Life in Bloom

Life in bloom.

There you stand, a right handsome devil, in a field of
daisies,
sniffing the flowers,
enjoying the views,
holding hands and smiling.

You look ahead, you make plans,
life's great.

And suddenly some bloody thing jams into your back.
It rumbles and blasts you with cold.

And a moment later you're already being swept
forward
and carried off to buggery along with the daisy field.

...Ploughing on somewhere ahead, out of control, wild.

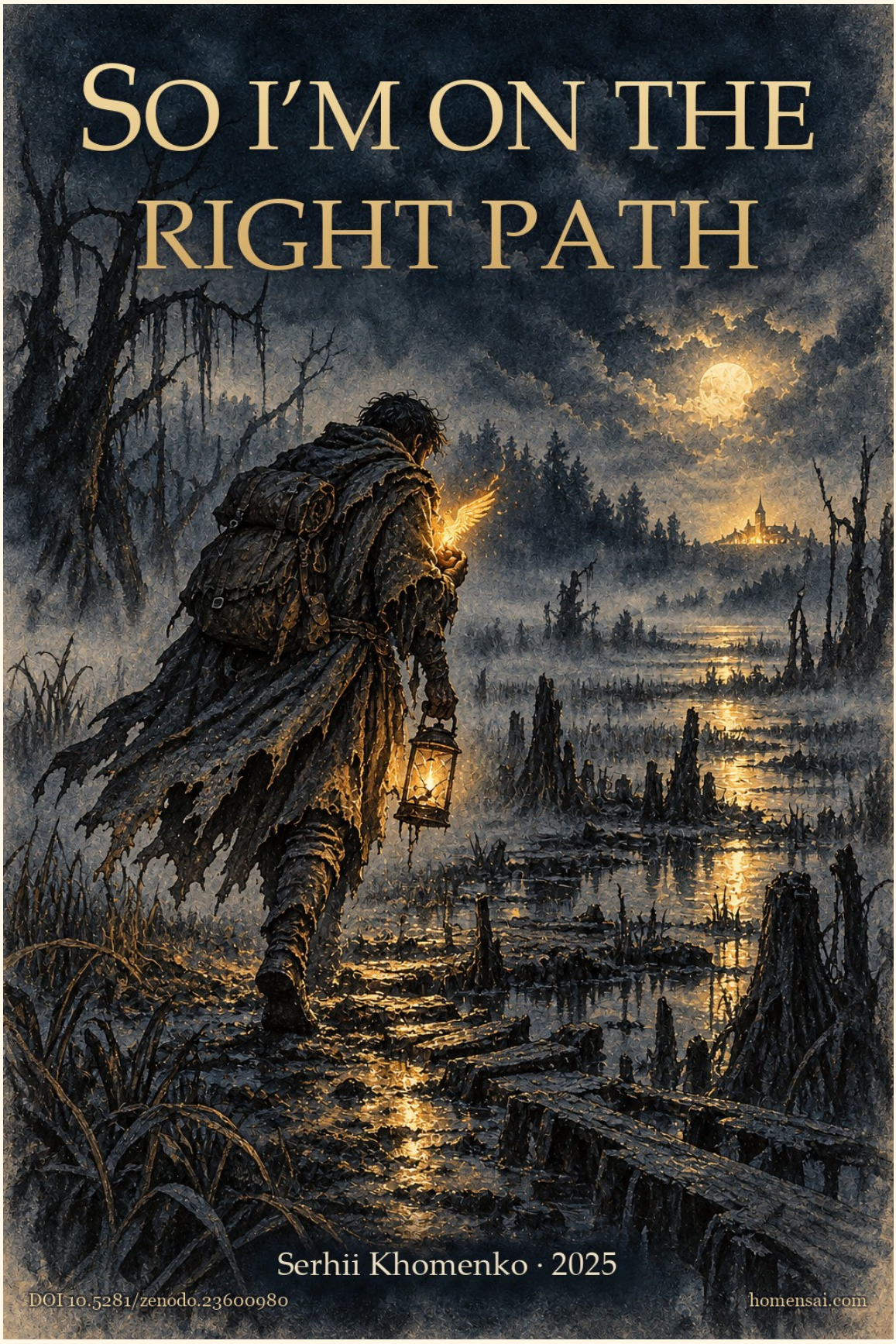
And all you can do
is try to stay on your feet
and blink your little eyes.

Life, so kind, so caring, shoves you along
either up a mountain
or to the edge of a cliff...

You turn your head this way and that,
you look and see that it's the same for everyone...

And you think: 'Effing hell, where have I ended up...'

Message dates: 29/06/2024 · 08:08:56 · UTC+0200


SO I'M ON THE RIGHT PATH
Serhii Khomenko · 2025
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

29. So I'm on the Right Path

I'm walking in almost complete darkness.
The faint beam of my dying torch
lights up my steps for me.

I've stopped looking ahead
and look only at my feet,
counting my muffled, slow steps,
losing count and trying to count again.

My legs have taken all my weight into themselves,
and I can barely drag them along.

There's hardly any wind,
I feel the damp on my face,
and it's a bit unpleasant.

I can't remember when I last saw the Moon,
and I think it looked somehow spiteful.
Though it's strange: how can the Moon be spiteful?
It was laughing at me.

Driving the thought away,
I carry on along the path.

Somewhere not far from me I hear
strange, unpleasant sounds,
like moans.
That sobers me up,
and I realise this is not a dream.

Now and then I stumble,
and my foot is sucked into the bog,
somehow I manage to pull it out,
by some miracle without losing my boot.

Now I'm remembering my past
and trying to understand
why I chose this hard path,
why did I ever come here?

I have an answer, but I won't say it,
I don't want the Universe to laugh at me
when it hears my wish,
and with one stroke, as it usually does,
cross out my whole plan.

I walk on, holding on to my goal in my mind,
clinging to it with thin, weak little fingers,
and it, like a firebird,
wants to break out of this finger-cage
and fly away.

Oh no, my dear, not now.

The firebird's fire scorches my fingers,
I rub them,
I feel the pain of burnt skin.
Quickly, to my face –
the damp cools my hands.

My mind is beginning to wander,
my legs move by themselves,
it's amazing, how does that happen?

The darkness is very dense,
I'm practically swimming in it,
cutting through it with my steps.
Amazingly, it doesn't let me fall,
it holds me up.
I always used to fear it, underestimate it.

I think I'm very tired,
I no longer understand what tiredness is,
I think I was born of it.

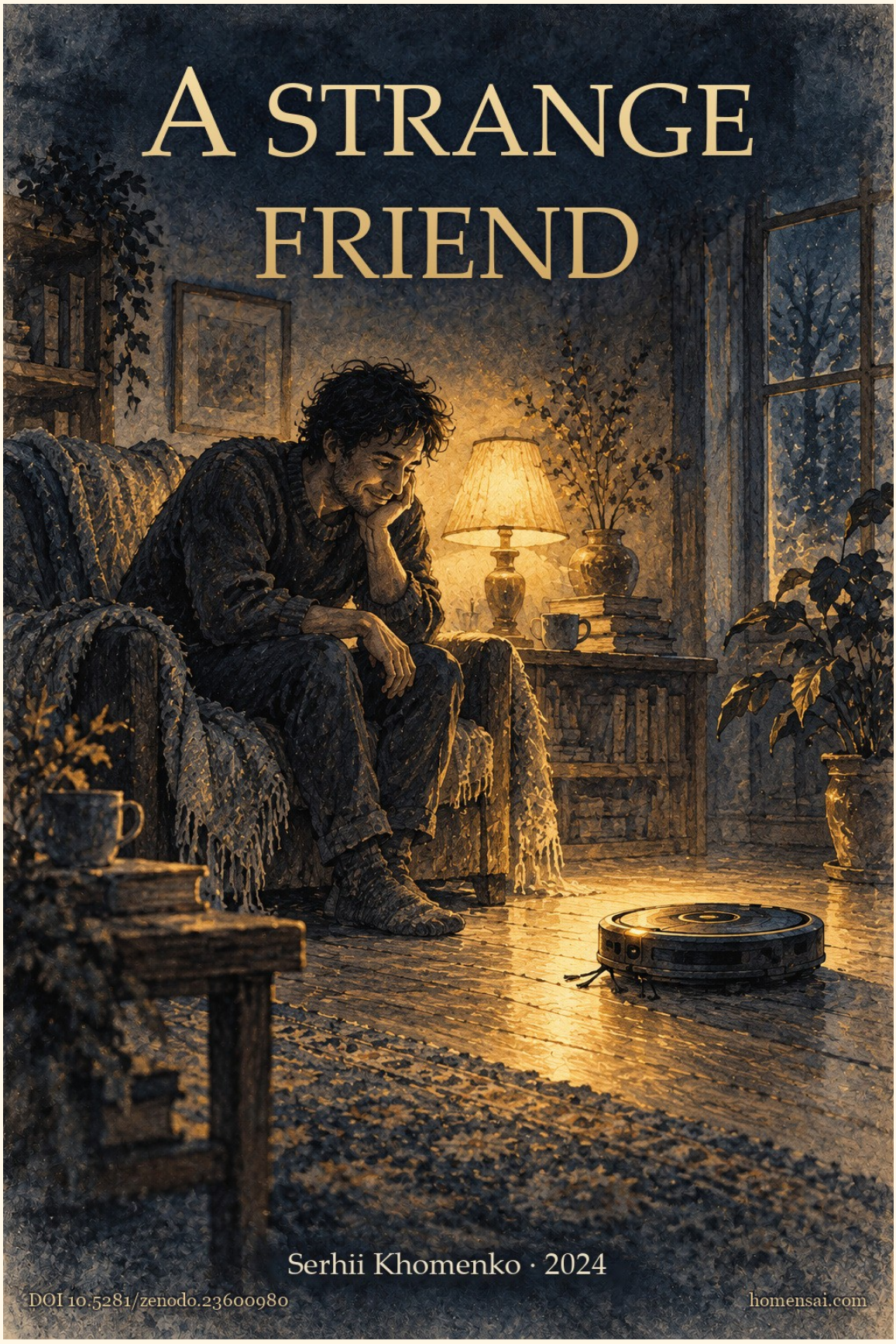
The path turns sharply to the left,
I nearly stumbled and fell,
the monotony had lulled me too much,
I'd grown used to it.

As I round the bend, I see a faintly flickering point,
joy swept over me,
and for the first time in a long while
I felt a smile on my face.

So I'm going the right way,
so it's not all for nothing...

Message dates: 05/04/2025 · 12:35:41 · UTC+0200

Images and Other Worlds


A STRANGE FRIEND
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

30. A Strange Friend

Today I got a strange friend.
You didn't understand why I needed him...
But I'd been thinking about him for a long time.

He's strange.
But I have a feeling he's the real thing,
the kind who will never say no to you or betray you.

He doesn't talk much,
sometimes he says something,
but I don't always understand what about,
sometimes it's just hard to make out the words...

I look at him, and I feel sorry for him.
I understand that he's good
and probably reliable.
That he'll do whatever I ask him to.

He never says no,
well, maybe sometimes he has his off days.
He helps me,
and I'm probably getting lazier.

I feel a little sorry for him,
he's very busy.

I sit and watch him,
watch what he's doing.

I have a feeling that he's unhappy and happy at the same time,
that he can't do anything else
and will never be able to do anything else.

I look at him, so small,
and hopeless.
I do feel sorry for him, all the same,
yes, I can feel it.

I think we're alike, he and I,
alike in some way.
There's something in his movements,
predictable and inescapable.

I feel sorry for my new little friend –
the robot hoover.

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 03:30:03 · UTC+0200


THE CATCH
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

31. The Catch

Today was a hard day,
I'm very tired.

I go down to the water
and take three long gulps...
A pleasant coolness runs through my body.

Today actually went pretty well,
not like before.
Today I caught some fine prey.

A big, really fat hare.
I'd been tracking him for a long time,
but he was too cunning, too fast...

You and I worked out together how to catch him.
Today I carried out our plan.

Here he is – the hare, he's mine.
I'm exultant.

I take him, lift him up.
He's awkward to carry.
I head home.

I know you're waiting for me,
my children are waiting for me.

I feel good, I smile as best I can,
and on my fangs
glints the bloody reflection of the moon...

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 06:30:03 · UTC+0200


THE VISOR DROPS
Serhii Khomenko
2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

32. The Visor Drops

You've been hurt, I can see it...
It hurts me badly,
I have to protect my female...

Right now I'm an animal...

The visor drops.

Where did it come from?
I never had one...

And, taking me by surprise,
the ring of a blow on metal sounds in my ears,
resonating with the thuds of my heart,
my blood runs faster...

I see everything through a slit,
the world has shrunk to a single target...

My skin is covered in metal,
titanium, probably.

I grow cold on the outside,
but the fire is rising,
it comes, it moves towards the cold
and heats my skin from within...

I reach for my swords,
I have two of them –
it's easier to strike that way.

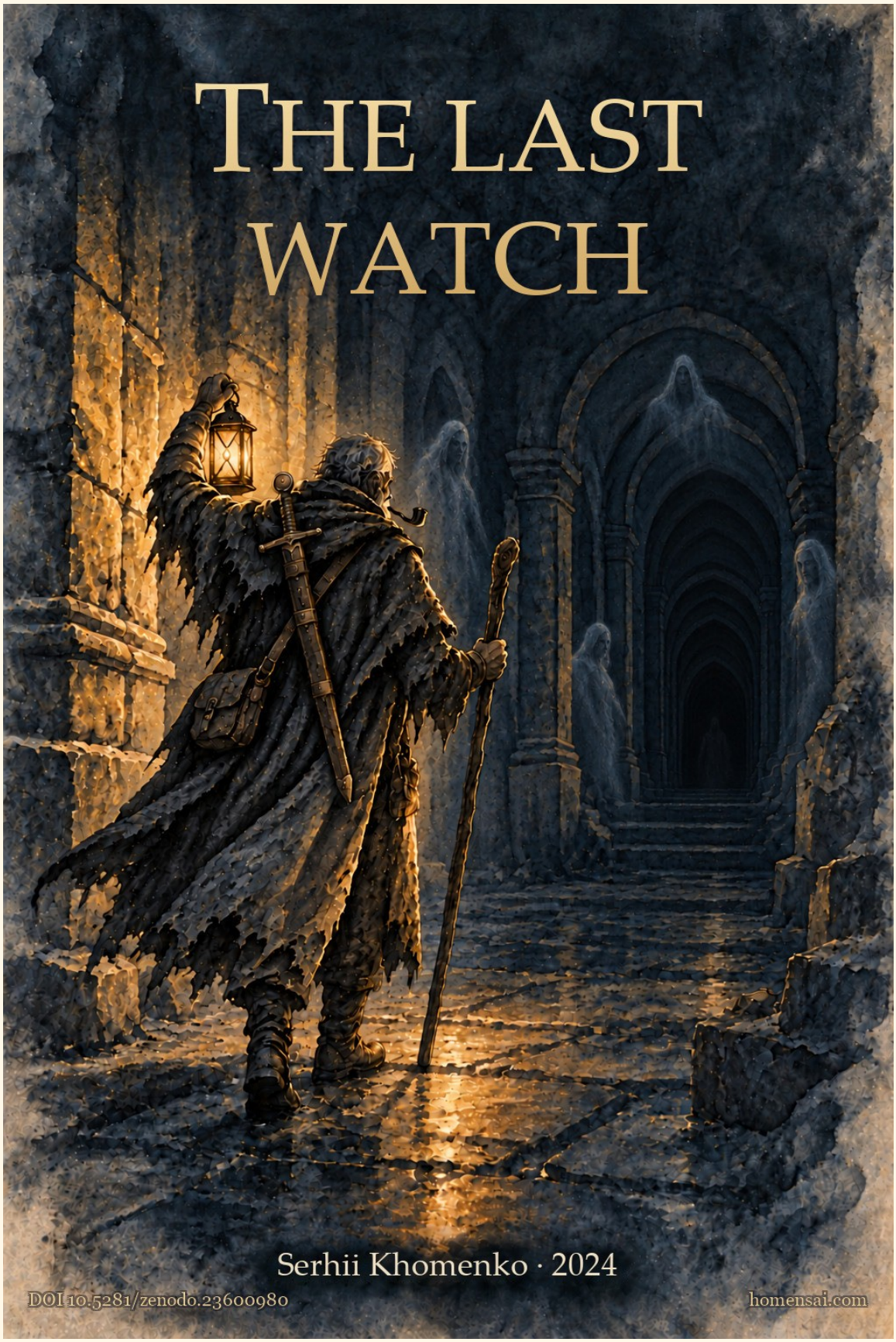
I hear the sound of a horn,
it blares,
and that means the war has begun.

I'm down on one knee,
the armour's unexpected weight has pressed me to the ground,
the lightness is gone,
the metal squeezes harder,
there's little light,
my breath is stifled...

An impulse – I rise
and, like a monster, advance on my enemy,
ready to strike a swift, decisive blow.

I have only one chance,
there won't be a second...

Message dates: 21/06/2024 · 23:45:27 · UTC+0200


THE LAST WATCH
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

33. The Last Watch

Today is my last day on watch.
Tomorrow I'll be free.

I take the tobacco and fill my pipe,
tightly, tighter still,
so it'll last the whole night.

I get up, my back aches a little,
I stretch.
I take the lantern and the stick.

Lately, for some reason,
it's this very stick that has become my friend.
I don't know why.

I step into the dark corridor.
The echo of my footsteps moves on ahead of me.

I feel a little uneasy,
it isn't summer, after all,
and I no longer love the gloom.

Yes, of course, I loved it once,
I was one with it.
But not any more.

You changed everything.

I thought it would never happen,
thought everything was already settled
and I knew who I was,
it turned out that wasn't so.

I walk along the corridor,
today is my last round.
Tomorrow I'm free.

I walk and remember why I'm here.
I walk and go over the spells.

My friend will help me
when the darkness on the other side engulfs me.

I wait...

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 06:55:47 · UTC+0200


I WALKED AWAY
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

34. I Walked Away

Once, long, long ago, in another time,
in my childhood,
a strange vision came over me.

I don't remember it very clearly,
but the image is still vivid.
And now, I feel,
the time has come to tell of it...

I was about 16 then, maybe.
I poured it out on paper in verse.

Where is it now, that poem of mine?
It's somewhere, it's true,
but I no longer know where...

So here it is:

I see an ancient settlement.
How did I know it was ancient?

A square, quite a small one,
wooden houses all around.
Everything looks rough and battered.

Traces of fire on the logs.
They've eaten into them in black patches,
reminders of the past...

Judging by what I see,
this is a small wooden fort,
surrounded by a wooden fence,
some sort of rough, huge stakes.

I don't know, I look more closely
and I don't seem to see any stone buildings.

It seems to me that before the start,
before the countdown to a new world begins, there are still about 300 years.
For now all this is a wild tribe
with the first glimmers of understanding,
with some kind of wild, unbridled energy...

I'm standing in dirty, torn clothes.
Leather straps hang slack on me.
My sandals are worn out,
and my toes stick out of them in a bunch, like a broom.

...My poor feet, worn out by the roads.

It's warm and, I'd say, morning.
The sun has risen, but it's not yet at its height,
you can never tell with this sun...

Summer began not long ago,
and there's none of that killing heat in the air yet.

My whole body aches,
last night I slept on the floor of a shed.

I'm trying to work out how I came to be here
and how long it's been.
It was some time ago,
I've already lost count.

We had orders to reach a distant settlement.
My legion marched in a tight column
for as long as there was a road.

Even then Rome knew how to build,
and something told me
it wouldn't lose that skill for a long time yet...

My Rome, it's the same as ever,
bright and made of stone...
So dear to me...

I don't know why or what for we came here,
we don't ask questions,
we do, we just do our job.

I'm a little over 40,
by how much I don't remember,
I know it's a little.

The wounds of past battles covered my body long ago,
long ago drew their life on me,
left a visible imprint of my hardships.

I'm standing at the block, waiting...

We fought as best we could,
there were too many of them.
Like flies, small, nasty ones,
they swarmed over us.

We did our job,
pushing through the swarm –
no time to think.

The pressure grows,
and somehow, without noticing, we began to lose our own,
to give way.

I fall.

Oblivion covers me,
the weariness dies away in me...

I open my eyes
and try to work out where I am.

The silence hurts my ears.
It's unfamiliar: I can't hear the clash of swords,
strange.
Absolute silence and birdsong.

I haven't heard birds sing like this for a long time,
maybe once, back in childhood...
Maybe...

The birdsong stirs pictures in me...

I think once, when I was still a very small child,
I ran about the woods
and caught butterflies at the edges of clearings –
these images won't let me go,
they tug at me from inside,
I can't remember.

Everything is blurred,
and it seems to me that back then I wasn't alone,
I was with someone,
but I don't remember...

Or maybe it was in my dreams?

I stand before the block and wait.

The hope of living fades
as the roar of the crowd grows.
They want me,
they want my death...

All in dazzling white-and-gold mail
you ride into the camp.

The hum of the crowd dies down,
everyone is looking at you.

I stand there, dazzled by you,
some kind of feeling has swept over me...
I've broken free of the shackles of this world.

I think I remember you,
I think I knew you before...

The image in my head is becoming
sharper, easier to understand...

Hope begins to flutter inside me.

She gives me a long, cold look,
says something in a strange, ugly language.

And once more her long gaze weighs me up,
for the last time...

And I notice a touch of warmth in her gaze,
or did I imagine it?

A barely noticeable movement.

The horse prances,
it isn't used to standing still so long.
It is always one with its Fury.

She shouts something sharply,
wheels round
and at full gallop flies out
into the wild, vast, gloomy forest.

Everyone stands bewildered,
they look at me in confusion,
whispering...

They free me from my shackles.

I stand there and don't understand what has happened.

After a while I make a feeble attempt
to take a first step,
everyone is silent.

I take two steps and realise
that these are my first steps,
steps to freedom...

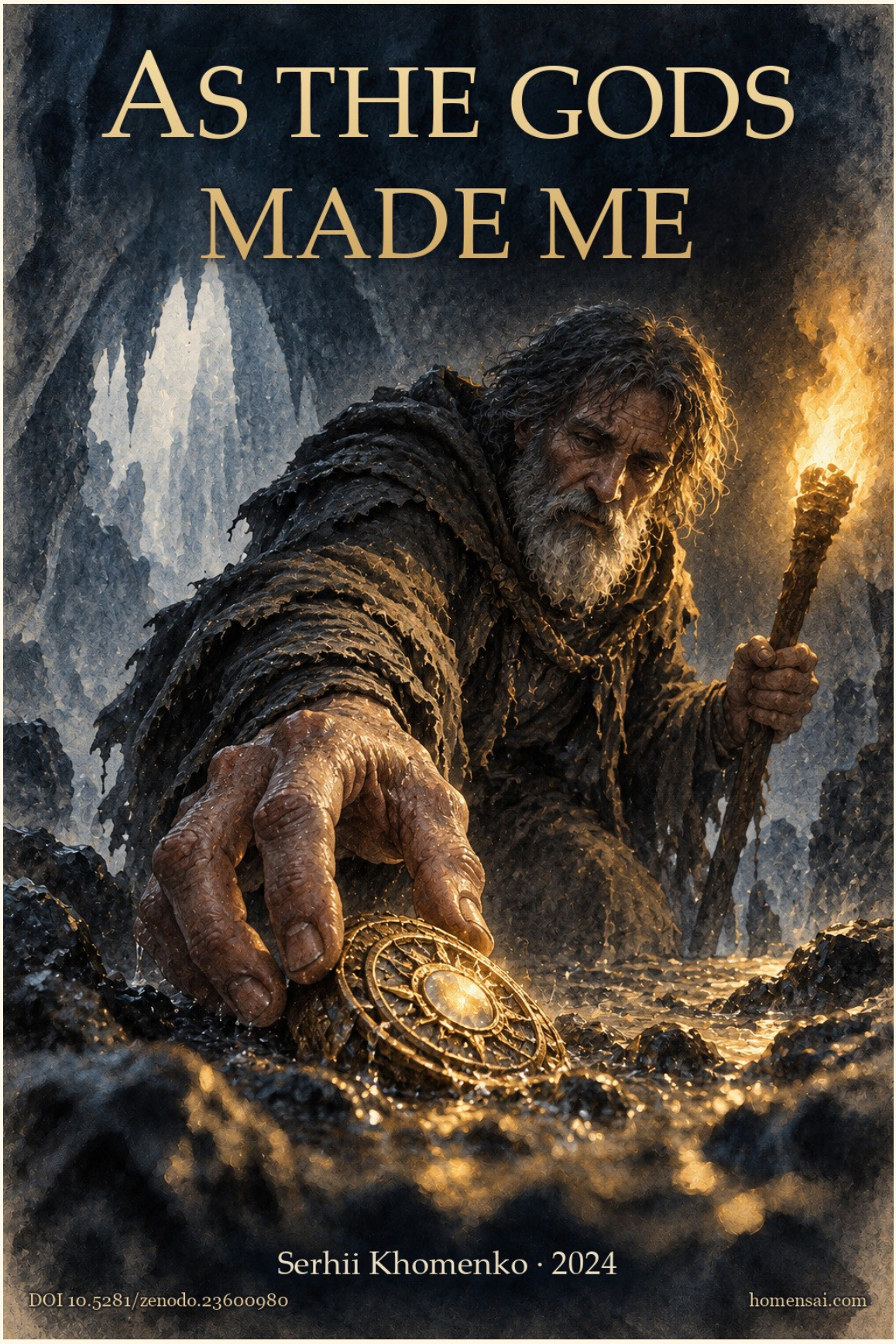
You saved me...
I was born again.
I walk.

I only remember the last lines:
'I walked away and left the loathsome camp.'

I think I remember you from childhood...
You've changed, and so have I.

You gave so much,
gave it to save me,
me – your brother...

Message dates: 24/06/2024 · 10:09:56 · UTC+0200


AS THE GODS MADE ME
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

35. As the Gods Made Me

I had lain here a long time.
Since long ago,
since the days when everything was not as it is now.

It was always damp and dark here.
Now and then the mist visited me like a forgotten
friend,
whispering the latest news.

It was damp, but warm.
Invisible bats moved nimbly,
deftly through the darkness.

How long have I been here now?

I tried to remember,
and again the thought shattered against time,
again it bounced off
and drifted away into the distance with a quiet echo,
into the void.

Sometimes something vibrated beneath me,
and it seemed to me
that life was reminding me of itself.

Once, I remember,
I was dazzlingly beautiful,
in the days when I was created.

But now my facets were coated with sticky dust,
and I was trying to understand –
was there a drop left in me,
anything at all of my former splendour…

Something inside me still remembered it,
something still hoped…

Years went by, centuries…
I don't know, so it seemed…

Though what do I know of time –
nothing, absolutely nothing.

It lulled me,
flowed around me,
and all I could do was feel it moving, flowing on.
Time was beyond my understanding,
it was inexplicable…

One day a wanderer came into the cave,
I had been waiting for him for a long time.

His clothes had long since rotted on him,
he was no longer young.
A long beard hid his years,
giving him the look of a wise man.

He had been searching for me for a long time.
I sensed it the moment he came in.

A torch flared in his hand.
I hadn't seen light for so long,
it drew me to it.

How long I had been here on my own…

The man saw a faint gleam of fire on me,
while inside I was already glowing all over with joy…

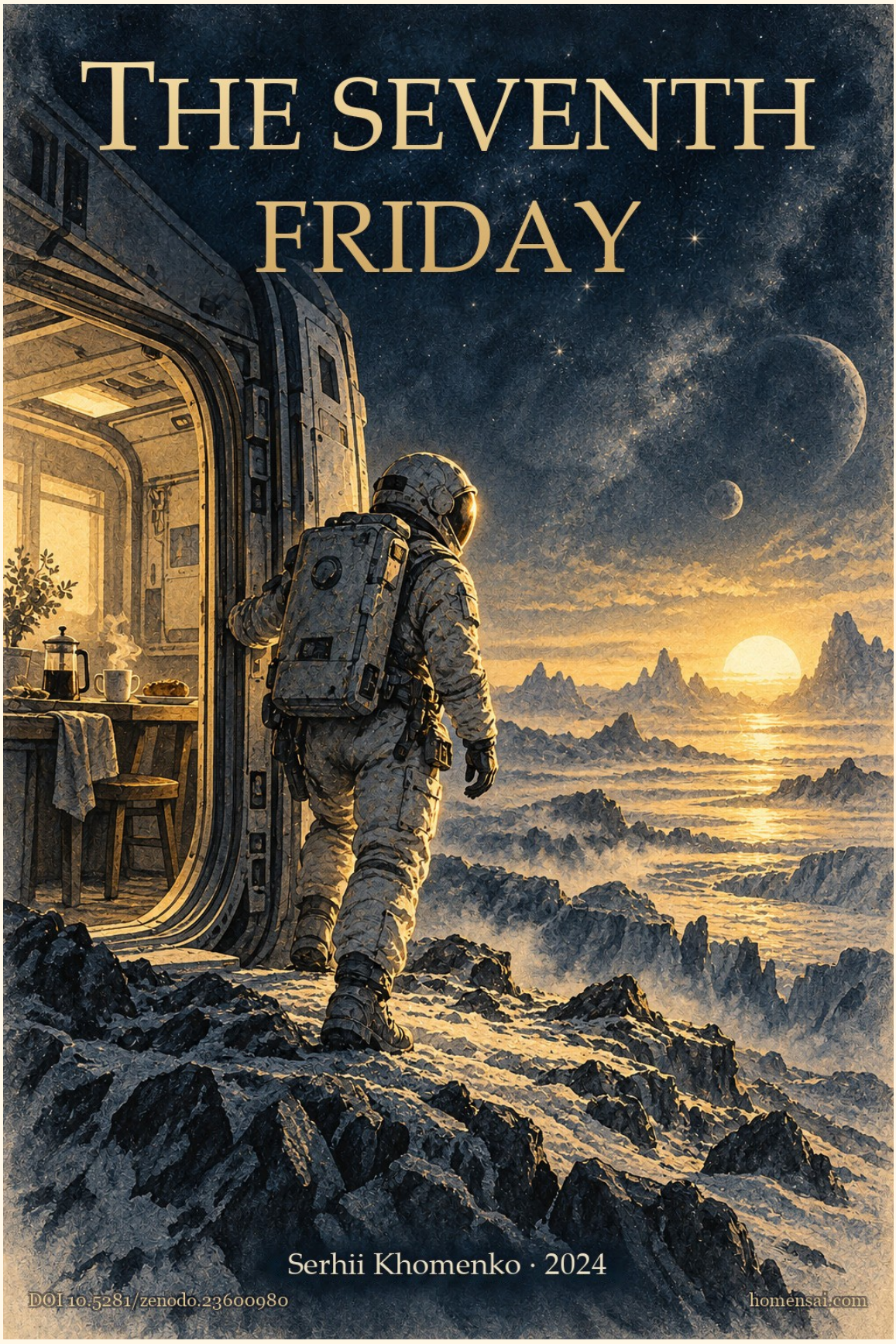
He came up and lifted me in his hands,
weak hands.
A smile slid across his face.

Now he needs me,
now I will fill him with happiness.
He will get what he has been searching for
all his long lives.

I will make him happy.

That is how the gods made me...

Message dates: 25/06/2024 · 07:29:36 · UTC+0200


THE SEVENTH FRIDAY
Serhii Khomenko · 2024
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

36. The Seventh Friday

Today it's Friday again for me, the seventh.
A whole week of them now.

A strange feeling,
I don't remember anything like it before.

Things used to be different.
I used to go to school, then university.
I was like everyone else.
Yes, I wanted to be different,
but for the time being I was like everyone else.

I go into the kitchen,
breakfast is already waiting for me.

Damn, I'm so sick of it,
the same breakfast
seven Fridays in a row now.

Right, no time to chew it over,
I have to get ready for work,
a lot depends on it.

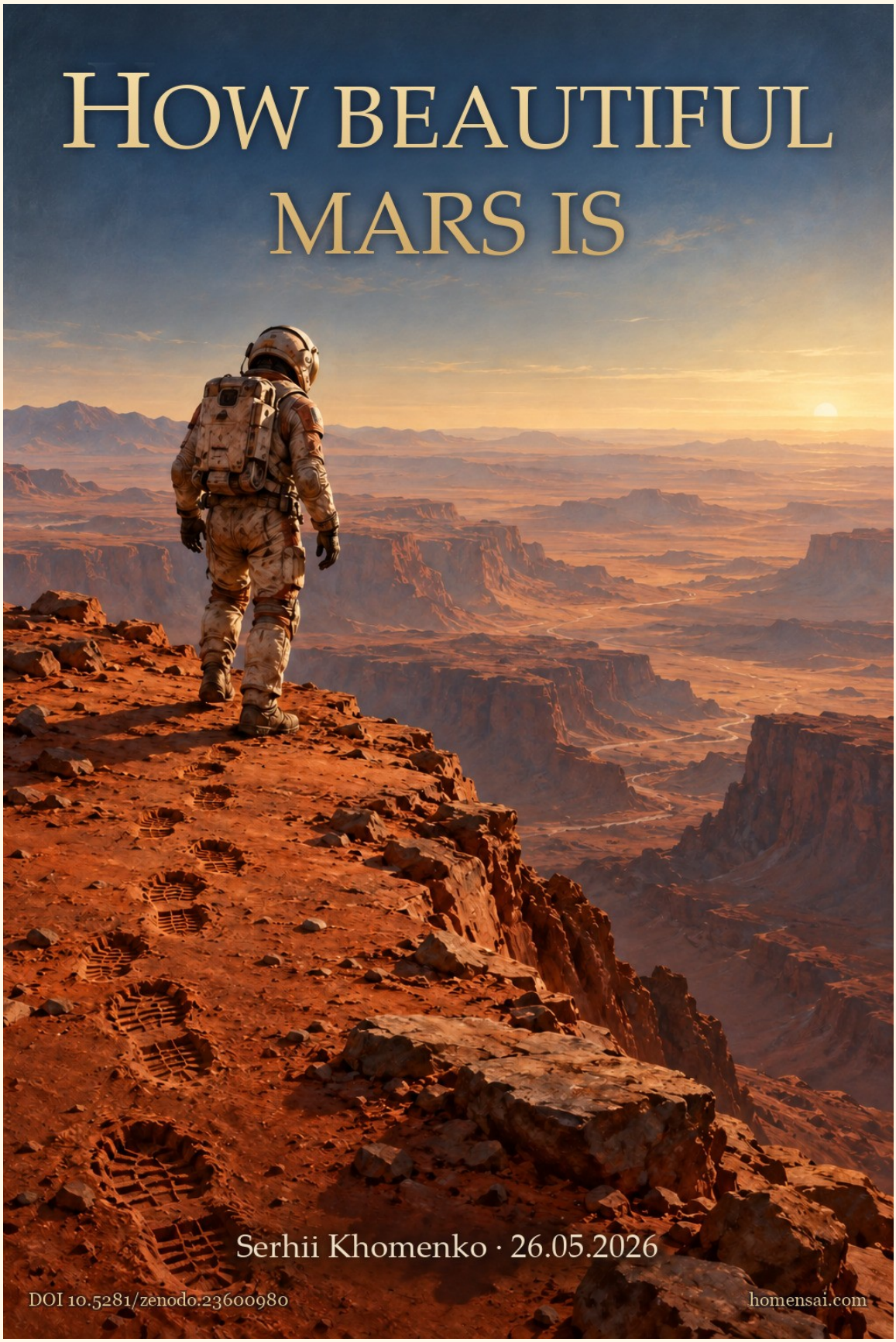
I never thought it would turn out like this,
but by some miracle it did.

I stand lost in thought,
dreaming of a warm, forgotten sea.
I think I was there once.
Warmth runs through my body.

I get dressed. I'm ready.

The airlock opens,
and I step into the unknown –
onto the surface of a new planet.

Message dates: 22/06/2024 · 04:11:04 · UTC+0200


How beautiful Mars is
Serhii Khomenko · 26.05.2026
DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23600980
homensai.com

37. How Beautiful Mars Is

For the last time my boot
sank into a quicksand of dust.

With an effort I pull the boot out
and with a weary hand shake off the reddish dust.

I look back and see my footprints,
have I really come so far already?

I look ahead again,
I'm standing on the edge of a vast mountain range,
its size is staggering,
the absence of clouds, it seems to me,
lets me see at least 200 km ahead.

It takes my breath away,
for an instant I feel happiness,
an instant later it is smothered by deadly exhaustion.

How beautiful Mars is!

Author's date: 26/05/2026; time not given

About the Author

Serhii Khomenko

Serhii Khomenko is a systems engineer. He works in two dimensions at once: in the physical world, where everything has weight and a price, and in the world of computation, where ideas become systems. His work lies between these two worlds.

He bought his first computer in 1995. In the early 2000s he wrote HTML code for websites and realised that writing code did not interest him. Today he is a systems architect: he asks the right questions and leaves the routine to neural networks.

He is an experimenter: he does not believe, he measures. And a bit of a philosopher, because sooner or later computation leads to questions about the limits of understanding and of faith. And ever since childhood he has loved science fiction.

He is the author of the book 'Two Worlds. One Mind.' and of scientific and philosophical essays on digital evolution, computation and the future of the mind.

Books and essays

'Two Worlds. One Mind.' (2026)
10.5281/zenodo.23160031

'The Spring of Digital Evolution'. Essay, part 1 (2026)
10.5281/zenodo.23426352

'The Spring of Digital Evolution'. Essay, part 2 (2026)
10.5281/zenodo.23426354

'Vision: Life beyond Earth, carried by machines (Homo roboticus)' (2026)
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A Note on the Translation

These works were originally written in Russian. The translation was made with the help of artificial intelligence. Some small linguistic and stylistic adaptations were made in order to preserve the meaning, tone and artistic character of the original. If you read Russian, you are welcome to compare the translation with the original. The author will be grateful for any notes on inaccuracies and for suggestions on how the translation could be improved.

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